

TIGER BY THE TAIL

With elections looming large and little going right for the DMK, Chief Minister Karunanidhi chooses to fall back on the emotive issue of Sri Lankan Tamils and put the Centre in a tight spot



TESTING THE WATERS: The Opposition's taunts forced Karunanidhi to take a new stance while daughter Kanimozhi (below) was the first MP to resign

■ By S. Senthil Kumar

The spectre of another no-confidence motion stalks the UPA Government. This time it is the complex and emotive issue of the Sri Lankan Tamils that threatens to rip apart the ruling coalition. An all-party meeting on October 14 held in Chennai decided unanimously to issue an ultimatum to the Central Government to "stop the massacre of innocent Tamils in Sri Lanka and bring its Government to the negotiating table" with the much-feared Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) within two weeks, failing which members of Parliament elected from Tamil Nadu would resign.

The meeting was boycotted by the AIADMK, MDMK, DMDK and BJP, who claimed it was just eyewash. Of the 39 MPs from the state, barring two, all belong

to the UPA. They will be missed by the Government if the Opposition moves a no-confidence motion.

The ultimatum, according to Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and DMK patriarch M. Karunanidhi, a key Congress ally, will be executed within 14 days if the Government does not act on their demands. MDMK leader Vaiko, who walked out of the UPA to tie up with J. Jayalithaa's AIADMK didn't attend the all-party meet but was belligerent on his pet cause. "We want the Centre to put pressure on the Sri Lankan Government to stop the murders of innocent Tamil civilians and push them to the negotiating table. Indian Embassy in Sri Lanka should be withdrawn as a pressure tactic," he said.

The all-party meet claimed that "the resolution to resign reflects the collective opposition to large-scale



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massacre of innocent fellow Tamils in Sri Lanka". Last week's resignation of Karunanidhi's daughter, Kanimozhi, from the Rajya Sabha would have been symbolic of the determination of the MPs but for the fact that she was careful enough to hand her resignation, not to the Rajya Sabha chairman, but to her father. "Three lakh Tamils are expected to be displaced due to the strife in Sri Lanka. By involving the international community, India should ensure